

## Chapter 115\_1 - Grievance

Qiu Yi hesitated with her toes touching the ground for a while, then tentatively asked: "Master, do you really want to go?"

Chu Qingqiu looked toward the end of the long street and hummed in agreement.

Half an hour later, the two stood outside a dilapidated temple on the outskirts of Ye City. This place seemed somewhat out of place amid the spring scenery - tattered banners swayed in the wind, moss covered the stone steps, and broken stones were scattered left and right, apparently having fallen from the brick walls.

The temple enshrined the Child-Giving Guanyin<sup>1</sup>, but it had obviously been without incense offerings for a long time. The paint on the Guanyin statue had weathered away by half.

Qiu Yi circled around front and back, somewhat hesitant: "I heard those magpies say it's right here, but..."

Chu Qingqiu stood at the bottom of the stone steps, gently closed her eyes, slightly parted her lips and silently recited a long incantation, then drew out her white bone weapon. The white jade flute spun several times between her fingertips, tracing out a complex formation.

Then she softly said "Open," and the formation sank into the earth's core. At the same time, the dilapidated temple before them seemed to have its covering forcefully torn away, revealing its true appearance from head to toe.

The pitch-black gates were several zhang<sup>2</sup> high, with a withered beast head hanging on each side of the door. The severed sections still bore bloodstains, as if they had been cut from demon beasts and hung up recently.

There was nothing behind the gates. Walking around them revealed only the mountain cliffs behind the city outskirts. Only the two great gates stood in the earth, somewhat eerie.

"Who comes?" One of the beast heads suddenly opened its mouth, its dry eyeballs grinding as they turned over, a sight that made one's hair stand on end.

"Chu Qingqiu." Chu Qingqiu said without changing expression.

"Who is Chu Qingqiu?" The other beast head also opened its mouth, its voice rough. "Never heard of you, won't let you in!"

Chu Qingqiu's mouth tightened slightly. She gently pushed her palm toward the front, and the white bone weapon in her hand immediately shot forward like an arrow from a bow, easily piercing through the iron gate like inserting into tofu.

The two beast heads opened their mouths in terror, then without another word twisted to either side, causing the great gates to open with a crash, revealing the narrow passage inside.

The passage sloped downward overall, extending to an unknown destination.

"It's actually an underground palace." Qiu Yi said quietly. She looked at Chu Qingqiu, watching as she silently entered, then followed herself.

The palace gates slammed shut the moment the two entered. Eternal flames lit up on both sides of the corridor, becoming brighter the further in they went, until at the end they were bright as daylight, so dazzling one couldn't open their eyes.

Passing through the piercing light was like passing through a barrier. When their eyes could finally see clearly again, Qiu Yi couldn't help but open her mouth wide. Before them was a broad stone bridge with flowing water tinkling below. Countless koi swam in the water, with occasional golden ones that could illuminate half the bridge.

Across the stone bridge were several archways, each connected by platforms. The platforms were adorned with floral stone carvings, while below the platforms flowed babbling water. Though the entire underground palace was shrouded in night, it didn't feel oppressive at all.

"This place doesn't seem as terrifying as they described." Qiu Yi said, following behind Chu Qingqiu as they passed through archway after archway. At the end of the archways was a three-way intersection leading to three different areas within the underground palace.

"The left path, supposedly, is what Ning Fuyi uses for... entertainment." Qiu Yi hesitated for a long time before she could say the word, finally using "entertainment" as a substitute. "Master, this entire journey has been unobstructed - there might be a trap."

Chu Qingqiu hummed in acknowledgment.

Her fingertips hidden in her sleeves tightened, and she steadied herself before walking toward the left. Qiu Yi looked worried but didn't dare say much.

The music in her ears became increasingly clear, and she could occasionally hear women's laughter. Rich fragrance drifted to her nose with the wind, so intoxicating it made one dizzy.

The final archway led to the end. Chu Qingqiu suddenly stopped and blocked Qiu Yi: "Qiu Yi, wait outside."

Qiu Yi was still worried, but before she could speak, Chu Qingqiu interrupted her.

"I'll be fine." She said softly, then patted Qiu Yi's shoulder and went forward alone.

Qiu Yi bit her lip and turned around, but unexpectedly a hand landed on her shoulder, pulling her toward the water. She instinctively wanted to cry out, but her mouth was also covered. After a dizzy spinning, she stumbled and fell into a room.

The hand covering her mouth quickly left, but a pleasant strange fragrance lingered. Qiu Yi was stunned for a moment before she could see clearly the smiling woman leaning against the door before her.

Her gaze immediately began to dodge, and she crawled up and retreated to the corner, her hands reaching for the knife behind her.

"What are you afraid of? Can I eat you or something?" Jiuying looked her over, then peered outside through the door crack. "In the current situation, don't cause trouble. If you're present as a disciple when there are certain things your master needs to say, how can she speak?"

Qiu Yi lowered her head and said nothing, but her hand didn't move from her waist.

Jiuying was attracted by her resistant appearance. She straightened her body, placed her hand on her waist, and gracefully moved forward a few steps, her voice drifting: "Why are you so afraid of me?"

"I, when was I afraid of you?" Qiu Yi turned her head away, not meeting those narrow, fox-like eyes. "What nonsense are you talking!"

"No matter how you put it, I raised you in the mortal realm for a year. Instead of being grateful, you act like a mouse seeing a cat whenever you see me." Jiuying pouted, leaning down close to Qiu Yi, finding her cornered appearance amusing.

Seeing Jiuying's bright red fingernails reaching toward her, Qiu Yi quickly closed her eyes tightly, but unexpectedly those cold fingertips didn't touch her. Instead, she heard a "pop" as a paper package was dropped.

Qiu Yi opened her eyes in confusion, only to see the beauty smiling brilliantly like the Milky Way, then with a fragrant breeze stirring, she gracefully moved away.

Only then did Qiu Yi's body soften. She swallowed saliva to moisten her dry throat and reached out to open the paper package.

Then she trembled again and nearly threw the package away.

It was actually a package of steaming hot, fragrant fried grasshoppers<sup>3</sup>!

At the end of the underground palace, the pipa<sup>4</sup> sounds entered the ears note by note - sometimes like a flock of birds taking flight, sometimes like heavy rain spattering, sometimes like soft sweet words clinging to the heart.

Ning Fuyi was half-reclining on a swing. This swing was wide enough for one person, adorned with flower garlands. As the ropes swayed, floral fragrance arose.

Several dancing girls surrounded her swing in dance, occasionally letting long sleeves fall into her palm, which she would gently pull, eliciting charming laughter from the women.

But Ning Fuyi seemed rather listless. She held an old booklet made of silk cloth in her hand, with a pile of ancient texts beside her, struggling to compare them.

A crow flew in from outside the door, fluttering down and transforming into human form: "Master, Du Baishuang has come out of the Punishment Hall<sup>5</sup> and says she wants to see you."

"Let her come." Ning Fuyi yawned and tossed aside the booklet.

Han Ya's<sup>6</sup> dark eyes turned, and she added: "Also... the Divine Venerable has arrived."

Ning Fuyi's yawn was cut short halfway, stuck in place. Then she closed her mouth, was silent for a while, and nodded: "Good."

Han Ya retreated, and then the door was pushed open. Du Baishuang, dressed in a white dress, stepped in, looking carefully toward Ning Fuyi.

She had a silk headband tied across her forehead, hidden among her hair and appearing intermittently. Her already palm-sized face appeared even more delicate and small, with black hair hanging down to her ankles along with her white clothes. Her posture was like wind - gentle and slender.

She walked to Ning Fuyi and knelt down softly, bowing her head: "Hall Master, this slave knows she was wrong. Hereafter she absolutely won't dare act on her own again."

She seemed extremely skilled at controlling her tears. The moment her knees touched the ground, tears began dripping down.

"Is what I blame you for acting on your own?" Ning Fuyi didn't look at her tears, nor at her face, but leaned among the flower garlands, using her fingertips to massage her temples.

"You're being punished not because you went to steal that worthless magical artifact, but because of your scheming mind." Ning Fuyi's tone was somewhat weary. "I have many matters to handle. Taking you in was only out of old affection, conveniently using you for my purposes. If you don't know your place and always want to play little schemes, then you should return to your Tianshan<sup>7</sup>."

Hearing this, Du Baishuang quickly wiped away her tears and said sadly: "No, this slave truly knows her mistake and will never commit it again."

"Don't send me back..." she sobbed.

Her previous crying had been somewhat false, but only this last sentence was genuine. Ning Fuyi glanced at her.

Du Baishuang was different from other spirit clan members. With her kind of body, who knew how many people coveted her. If she were truly left homeless, her fate would either be to be devoured by others or captured for forced cultivation use.

In her previous life, being offered as a gift to herself was already considered a good ending.

So her scheming desperately just to survive - honestly, Ning Fuyi was moved to pity.

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## Footnotes

<sup>1</sup> **Child-Giving Guanyin (送子观音)** - A form of the Buddhist goddess Guanyin (Avalokiteshvara) specifically worshipped by those seeking children or safe childbirth.

<sup>2</sup> **Zhang (丈)** - A traditional Chinese unit of measurement, approximately 3.33 meters or 11 feet.

<sup>3</sup> **Fried grasshoppers** - A traditional Chinese snack, particularly popular in certain regions. They're considered a delicacy and are often seasoned and fried until crispy.

<sup>4</sup> **Pipa (琵琶)** - A traditional Chinese stringed instrument, similar to a lute, with four strings and played with the fingers.

<sup>5</sup> **Punishment Hall (惩戒堂)** - A place within Chuwei Hall where disciplinary actions are carried out.

<sup>6</sup> **Han Ya (寒鸦)** - Literally "Cold Crow," one of Ning Fuyi's subordinates who can transform between crow and human form.

<sup>7</sup> **Tianshan (天山)** - Literally "Heavenly Mountains," referring to Du Baishuang's place of origin.